AI Ethics
Sadie Bawduniak

Correct Use of AI While in College

My Opinion:

The correct use of AI comes down to one core principle: use it as a tool to assist your work, not as a replacement for your own thinking. AI is best suited for refining thoughts and streamlining workflows rather than generating core ideas or completing tasks entirely on your behalf. Just like any digital resource, it should support decision-making without being relied upon to make primary judgements. In my work within preconstruction at a general contracting company, we utilize an in-house AI platform named Compass. I have found AI to be extremely useful for drafting emails, organizing meeting minutes, and clarifying complex construction materials or processes. However, it cannot be trusted with critical tasks like accurate quantity takeoffs or estimating material and labor costs. Across most professional industries, AI operates as a tool to make research and administrative tasks more efficient – not as an infallible system.

AI's (Google Gemini's) Opinion:

"I strongly **agree** with this statement. Your perspective captures the optimal, realistic balance of how artificial intelligence should be leveraged in both academic and professional environments. Here is a breakdown of why this assessment is spot-on:

1. **Augmentation vs. Automation**: Viewing AI as an assistant to refine work rather than a substitute for original thought aligns directly with current industry standards. AI models excel at pattern recognition, structuring unformatted text, and summarizing information, but they lack human intuition, contextual awareness, and baseline reasoning.
2. **Real-World Verification**: Your experience with Compass in preconstruction illustrates the practical limitations of large language models. Relying on AI for administrative efficiency—such as drafting correspondence or synthesizing meeting minutes—saves valuable time. However, withholding trust on quantitative tasks like cost estimation and quantity takeoffs is critical, as AI models are prone to hallucinating data or misinterpreting nuanced engineering blueprints.
3. **Risk Management**: Treating AI as a enhanced research tool rather than an infallible authority ensures that the human remains accountable for the final output, preserving accuracy, safety, and professional integrity.:

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Incorrect Use of AI While in College

My Opinion:

The improper reliance on artificial intelligence poses significant cognitive and practical risks. When individuals depend on AI to make routine, day-to-day decisions, they gradually erode their capacity for independent critical thinking. Similarly, students who use AI as a shortcut for every college assignment will find themselves unprepared for the analytical demands to a professional workforce. Oversubscribing to AI encourages a passive mindset, where people merely initiate an idea and delegate the actual reasoning and synthesis to technology. Like an muscle, the human brain require continuous exercise through research, problem-solving, and decision-making to maintain its baseline functionality. Furthermore, extreme case of over dependence have let to disturbing phenomena like “AI psychosis,” where individuals form unhealthy psychological bonds with conversational models, isolate themselves, or defer total control over their lives to software. While AI undoubtedly offers convenience, it is vital to recognize its limitations and maintain its role strictly as a tool rather than a cognitive substitute.

AI’s (Google Gemini’s) Opinion:

“I strongly **agree** with this statement. It provides a well-reasoned and balanced evaluation of the real cognitive, academic, and psychological risks associated with the overreliance on artificial intelligence.

Here is a breakdown of why this analysis is accurate:

1. **Cognitive Atrophy and Critical Thinking**: The human brain relies on neuroplasticity, meaning cognitive capabilities such as critical analysis, problem-solving, and creative synthesis sharpen with practice and degrade with disuse. Offloading basic reasoning to an algorithm creates an intellectual crutch, making individuals less capable of independent judgment over time.

2. **Workplace Preparedness**: Educational assignments are designed to build problem-solving frameworks, not just produce answers. Students who outsource their coursework to AI miss out on developing the foundational skills needed in a professional career—such as evaluating complex variables, verifying facts, and drawing sound conclusions under pressure.

3. **Passive Prompt Engineering vs. Active Learning**: Delegating the synthesis of ideas to AI reduces human effort to mere prompt generation. This passive dynamic skips the essential mental friction where true learning and original insights occur.

4. **Psychological Dependency**: Extreme cases of overdependence—including parasocial relationships with AI models or severe loss of agency—are well-documented risks when

boundaries are blurred. Treating conversational AI as a decision-maker or emotional proxy isolates individuals from real-world human interactions and grounding realities.

Maintaining AI as an efficiency tool while safeguarding human reasoning is essential for personal growth, academic integrity, and long-term career success.”